third, a longtime settler activist, talked about his efforts to buy up land in the West Bank and sell it to Jews. Someone in the audience asked if he had "any connections to Christians." He said no. The crowd applauded.

Little surprise, then, that Bennett's plan backfired. Ohana dropped out of the race within days, and only two secular candidates were elected to realistic spots. "It was the biggest gaffe anyone has made in Israeli politics in a long time," Bennett admitted.

Less embarrassing, but more telling, was the case of Dani Dayan, a man sometimes described as the "settler foreign minister." He traveled often to Europe and the United States to lobby on their behalf, and was well received by diplomats; he lives in Ma'ale Shomron, a settlement in the northern West Bank, and is a vocal opponent of the two-state solution. Bennett personally recruited him to run with the party.

But these right-wing credentials were not enough for the Jewish Home faithful, because Dayan is also secular. He once refused to tell an interviewer whether he believes in God. He grew tired of questions about his faith, or whether he observes Shabbat, and left the party after a poor showing in the primaries. "I understood quite early that I don't suit them, they don't suit me," he said later over coffee at a Jerusalem hotel. (The Argentine-born Dayan would soon be appointed ambassador to Brazil, only to have his nomination blocked when Brasilia refused to accredit a settler as Israel's chief envoy; Netanyahu eventually tapped him to be the consul-general in New York.)

The national-religious, as mentioned earlier, comprise nearly one-fourth of the Jewish population, much higher than previously thought, and they are gradually gaining prominent roles in politics, the army, and other institutions. But the community holds a number of views that are well outside the consensus, which puts a ceiling on the popularity of a party like the Jewish Home. Gay rights, for example, are something of a settled issue in Israeli society. Bennett faced almost universal criticism for his party's stance—though he himself supports equal benefits for same-sex couples (but not formal marriage), one of his candidates proclaimed himself "a proud homophobe." Dozens of gay soldiers responded by posting photos of themselves with their partners on Bennett's Facebook page. "You cannot be a nationwide leader in Israel in 2015 and be perceived as homophobic," said Dayan, who is a vocal supporter of gay rights.